

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 32

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A boy of twelve makes his first solo train journey across the country to spend the summer with his aunt.

1

My mother had written the instructions out twice, once on a folded sheet of pale blue paper that lived in my breast pocket, and once on the back of my ticket in her small, careful hand. **Do not get off before Halton Junction. Do not speak to anyone you do not know. If lost, find a guard in a red cap.** I had read them on the platform, on the steps of the carriage, and again in my seat, until I could see them with my eyes closed. My suitcase was on the rack above me. My sandwiches were on my knees. I was, my mother had assured me at the barrier, perfectly capable.

2

The carriage smelled of warm cloth and stewed tea. There were four other passengers: an old gentleman with a newspaper folded into a precise square, a woman in a green hat who closed her eyes the moment the train pulled away, a sailor whose duffel bag took up half the floor, and a girl perhaps seventeen years old who was writing letters with a pencil that needed sharpening. None of them looked at me. The lack of being looked at was, I discovered, far worse than being stared at. I sat as still as I could and tried to make my legs as long as a man's.

3

For the first hour the country slid past as if it were the country that was moving and not the train. Hedges, then fields, then a slow brown river, then a town whose name I did not catch. I ate one of my sandwiches at twenty past eleven, much earlier than I had meant to, simply because eating gave me something to do with my hands. The old gentleman with the newspaper folded his paper a quarter turn, glanced at me over the top of his spectacles, and said, with grave politeness, "A long journey ahead, young man?" I said, "Yes, sir," and felt myself blush to the roots of my hair. He nodded once and disappeared back behind his paper, as though the matter were now satisfactorily settled.

4

At Crewe the train stopped for what the guard, walking past, called “a few minutes only.” The sailor stretched, swung his duffel bag onto his shoulder, and got out. The woman in the green hat did not stir. I watched the platform clock: eleven minutes past twelve. I had, my mother had warned me, exactly twelve minutes at Crewe and on no account was I to leave the train. But the sailor, returning, had a paper cup of something steaming, and the smell of it through the open door was so warm and so adult that I stood up, told myself I would be quick, and stepped down onto the platform.

5

I bought a cup of tea from a kiosk where the woman called me “love” and gave me my change in coppers. I turned, holding the cup with both hands so as not to spill it, and saw, with a slow cold horror, that my train was no longer there. In its place stood a different train, longer, dirtier, facing the wrong way. For perhaps three seconds I could not breathe. Then a voice behind me — the guard in the red cap, exactly as my mother had said — touched my elbow and said, “Platform four, son. They moved her down. You’ve a minute.” I ran. I did not spill the tea.

6

Back in my seat, I drank the tea in small scalding sips and tried to look as though nothing had happened. The old gentleman lowered his paper a fraction of an inch. “A near thing, that,” he said mildly, and raised the paper again. He had been watching, I realised, the whole time. The girl with the pencil smiled at me without looking up from her letter. I did not feel embarrassed, quite. I felt, in some small and unfamiliar way, included — as if I had passed, in their company, a small examination that none of them had thought it polite to mention.

7

The last stretch of the journey was the easiest. I slept a little, my forehead against the cool glass. I woke when the train slowed at a small station whose sign read, in plain black letters, **Halton Junction**. My aunt was on the platform in her summer coat, waving with one gloved hand as if she had been waving for some time. I climbed down. I shook her hand because I was not sure whether one was meant to hug an aunt one had not seen in three years, and she laughed and hugged me anyway. “Well,” she said, holding me at arm’s length. “You came by yourself, then.” I said, “Yes,” and tried not to look too pleased with the word.

From Paragraph 1

1. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show how carefully the narrator’s mother had prepared him for the journey. [2]

2. The narrator says his mother had told him he was “perfectly capable.” Explain what this suggests about how the mother **wanted** her son to feel before the journey. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says, “The lack of being looked at was, I discovered, far worse than being stared at.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about the narrator’s state of mind in the carriage. [2]

4. What does the narrator mean when he says he “tried to make [his] legs as long as a man’s”? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator eats his sandwich “much earlier than [he] had meant to.” Give the reason he provides, and explain what it reveals about him. [2]

6. The old gentleman speaks to the narrator “with grave politeness” and then “disappeared back behind his paper, as though the matter were now satisfactorily settled.” What does this suggest about the old gentleman’s **manner** towards the boy? [2]

From Paragraph 4

7. The narrator describes the smell of the sailor’s drink as “so warm and so adult.” Explain why the word **adult** is significant here. [2]

From Paragraph 5

8. The narrator says he saw, “with a slow cold horror,” that his train was no longer there.

- (a) What is unusual about the words **slow** and **cold** being used together to describe horror? [1]
- (b) What does this phrase suggest about the narrator’s reaction at that moment? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The old gentleman says, “A near thing, that,” and raises his paper again. What does this short remark reveal about him? [2]

10. The narrator says he felt “included — as if [he] had passed, in their company, a small examination that none of them had thought it polite to mention.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

11. The narrator says he “tried not to look too pleased with the word” **yes**. What does this tell us about how he feels at the end of the journey? [2]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the strange new economics of professional eSports.****1**

For most of the twentieth century, sport meant something a parent could explain to a child in a single sentence: men and women, in matching shirts, kicking, hitting or throwing an object on a field. Today, in a development that would have baffled a sports editor of 1985, the most-watched sporting event of any given week is increasingly likely to involve no field at all. The League of Legends World Championship final in 2023 drew, by independent estimate, more than six million concurrent viewers — a figure that comfortably exceeds the audience for most rounds of the football World Cup. The arenas are full. The shirts have sponsors. The players are paid. They are simply, by traditional standards, in the wrong place: sitting at desks, in front of screens, playing video games.

2

The money in competitive video gaming — usually called eSports — flows through several channels at once. Tournament prize pools, funded by publishers and sponsors, can be enormous: the 2021 International, a tournament for the game Dota 2, distributed forty million US dollars in prize money to its competing teams. Team salaries, paid by professional organisations such as T1, Cloud9 or G2 Esports, can run from modest five-figure sums for newer players to seven-figure contracts for established stars. Above all, there are sponsorships. A top eSports player today is likely to earn more from a single endorsement deal — peripheral manufacturers, energy drinks, broadband providers — than from any tournament purse.

3

The career, however, is short. A professional footballer might play at the top level into his mid-thirties. A professional StarCraft player is, in industry terms, ancient at twenty-five. Reaction times, which can be measured in milliseconds, decline noticeably from the early twenties onwards, and the games themselves shift faster than human reflexes: a hero or weapon patched out of the game in a software update can erase, overnight, the technical edge a player has spent years building. Most professional eSports careers, according to a 2022 review by **Esports Insider**, last between four and seven years; many last fewer than three. Retirement at twenty-six is not unusual.

4

What sustains the industry through these short careers is, increasingly, the streaming platform. Twitch, owned by Amazon, and YouTube Gaming have together created a parallel economy in which a retired or even a non-professional player can earn a substantial income simply by playing in front of an audience. Viewers pay monthly subscriptions, send small one-off donations, or watch advertisements; the streamer takes a share. A successful streamer, even one who never wins a tournament, can earn more than a mid-table tournament professional. For many young players, the dream is no longer to win the world championship. The dream is to be watched.

5

This new economy has raised difficult questions about labour. Most eSports contracts are negotiated by teenagers, often without legal representation, against organisations with experienced lawyers and clear commercial interests. Hours are long: a competitive player at a top-level “boot camp” may practise for twelve to fourteen hours a day in the months before a major tournament, with little distinction between training, streaming and sleeping in the same building. Burnout is common. In 2022, the Korean player Faker — perhaps the most decorated eSports professional alive — required medical leave for a wrist injury that doctors attributed directly to overuse. Unionisation, the obvious remedy in traditional sport, has been slow to arrive. The Counter-Strike Professional Players’ Association, founded in 2018, remains the most established body, but it covers a small fraction of working players.

6

There is also the matter of age. Many eSports stars begin to compete seriously at fourteen or fifteen, and a handful win significant prize money before they are old enough to drive. Regulators in several jurisdictions — South Korea, China, the United Kingdom — have begun to ask uncomfortable questions about schooling, screen time and consent. A 2023 white paper from the International Esports Federation recommended a minimum competitive age of seventeen for the largest tournaments. The recommendation, predictably, was resisted by publishers whose youngest stars were also their most marketable.

7

Where the industry goes next is a matter of guesswork. Some analysts expect a gradual maturing — formal player unions, standardised contracts, salary floors of the kind that English football took a century to negotiate. Others expect the opposite: a fragmenting of the audience across smaller games and smaller platforms, in which the very idea of a “world champion” becomes harder to defend. Either way, the figure of the teenager at the desk, headphones clamped to his ears while six million strangers watch him play, has moved from oddity to ordinary in less than a decade. Whether the rules of his working life will, in time, become as ordinary as his audience is the question the next decade will answer.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the most-watched sporting event of a given week “is increasingly likely to involve no field at all.” Explain, in your own words, why this would have “baffled a sports editor of 1985.” [2]

13. The writer says eSports players are simply, “by traditional standards, in the wrong place.” What does this **ironic** phrase tell us about the writer’s attitude towards eSports? [1]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** ways in which eSports players earn money. [2]

From Paragraph 3

- 15.** The writer says a professional StarCraft player is “ancient at twenty-five.”
- (a) What is unusual about applying the word **ancient** to a person of this age? [1]
- (b) Why is this word appropriate in the context of eSports? [1]

16. Give **two** reasons, from Paragraph 3, why eSports careers are unusually short. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that, for many young players, “the dream is no longer to win the world championship. The dream is to be watched.” Explain, in your own words, what this change reveals about the eSports industry. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that boot-camp players have “little distinction between training, streaming and sleeping in the same building.” What does this suggest about their working lives? [2]

19. Why does the writer mention that the Counter-Strike Professional Players’ Association “covers a small fraction of working players”? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says the recommendation of a minimum age of seventeen was “predictably” resisted by publishers. What is the writer suggesting by the word **predictably**? [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends by describing “the teenager at the desk, headphones clamped to his ears while six million strangers watch him play.” What is **effective** about ending the article with this image? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **how professional eSports players earn money**, and **the difficulties faced by eSports players in their working lives**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Professional eSports players earn money through ...

— END OF PAPER —